

ANDELO

# The Design Capacity Formula

A guide to diagnosing your design workload and team capacity.



# Stop guessing. Start counting.



How many hours have you spent managing design, or even doing it yourself? Exactly. That's not your role, but you have to do it, otherwise the backlog just keeps piling up. It just happens: you don't even know if it's a capacity problem or an efficiency problem. What you know is that it's chaotic and causes burnout, for you and your team.

That's what this guide is about: ending that cycle. We'll help you diagnose the real issue step by step, so by the end you'll know your next step.

We use this framework to evaluate our own capacity every quarter. After a few years of refining it, we've found it's the most liberating way to find the real numbers and plan ahead. A few minutes of effort that saves you from unnecessary budget leaks. The final step will help you choose the right fit to close the gap.



## Step 1 Count Your Monthly Design Needs

What are your ongoing design needs? Take your time with this one: getting the list right is the first step. Then map it across the slow season, the regular months, and the peak. Use the table below to work out the average hours each one needs.

✓ Based on years of production work delivered across Australian marketing teams

| WHAT YOU'RE PRODUCING | QTY/MONTH            | AVG HOURS EACH           | TOTAL HOURS            |
|-----------------------|----------------------|--------------------------|------------------------|
| Social media posts    | <input type="text"/> | × 2.5h                   | = <input type="text"/> |
| EDMs                  | <input type="text"/> | × 4h                     | = <input type="text"/> |
| Presentations         | <input type="text"/> | × 8h                     | = <input type="text"/> |
| Flyers / posters      | <input type="text"/> | × 3h                     | = <input type="text"/> |
| Brochures             | <input type="text"/> | × 10h                    | = <input type="text"/> |
| Report pages          | <input type="text"/> | × 2h                     | = <input type="text"/> |
| Event collateral      | <input type="text"/> | × 4h                     | = <input type="text"/> |
| Banner / web assets   | <input type="text"/> | × 4h                     | = <input type="text"/> |
| Other                 | <input type="text"/> | x <input type="text"/> h | = <input type="text"/> |
| Total                 |                      | Production hours:        | = <input type="text"/> |

## Step 2 Add the Working Margin

Realistically, design has never been just the design. Think about it: from the first brief to the delivered file, plenty of things along the way cost time.

### WHERE DESIGN TIME REALLY GOES

### WHY IT MATTERS

#### Read the brief and research

Nobody starts designing right away. The designer needs to read and understand the task first. Especially if it's not a repeat task, fresh research is needed to understand the context fully.

#### Exploration

The outcome may look simple. Sometimes the designer hits it right straight away. Other times, a few iterations are needed to get to the right one.

#### Revision

One or two revisions are common. But sometimes a change of direction or a new idea causes many more, especially on tasks with plenty of stakeholders involved.

#### Context switch

The most underrated one. The more tasks and revisions come in, the more cooldown a designer needs between them, so a bit of buffer helps.

#### Late additions

Extra sizes, formats, or versions asked for after approval.

#### Final file preparation

Every output needs to be prepared and uploaded. Then a typo shows up, and another round of fixing and re-uploading has to be accommodated.

Now add those invisible activities to your time plan. On average, that takes around a 20% working margin. Then you get the real monthly need:

production hours

+

20

% margin

= monthly need

0h

From Step 1 ←

## Step 3 Count Your Real In-House Hours

Full-time is 38 hours a week: about 165 hours a month contracted. Take out leave and public holidays first and about 150 attended hours remain. A designer's real working time is around 80% of that: meetings, seeking creative inspiration, and peer communication take the rest. So a full-time in-house designer's real hours:



### Contracted hours

38h/week × ~4.33 weeks

**~165h**



### Minus paid leave

~41 days/year under Australian entitlements  
(annual, public holidays, sick), averaged

**~26h**



### Minus meetings & admin

~80% of the time that's left is billable design

**~111h**



### Real productive hours

what you can actually brief

**~110–120h/month**

| WHO                           | HOW MANY                                                                | REAL HOURS EACH | TOTAL |
|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|-------|
| Full-time designers           | <input type="text" value="0"/>                                          | × 120           | 0h    |
| Part-time designers           | <input type="text" value="0"/> × <input type="text" value="0"/> days/wk | ÷ 5 × 120       | 0h    |
| <input type="text" value=""/> | <input type="text" value="0"/> h real hours                             |                 | 0h    |
| Real monthly in-house hours   |                                                                         |                 | 0h    |

! Part-time is pro-rata from the same base: three days a week is about 72 real hours.

## Step 4 Work Out Your Gap

Now bring the two numbers together: what your month demands, minus what your team can hold. And because demand moves with the calendar, your result also includes the slow and busy seasons. Take your monthly need from Step 2 and multiply it by each season's factor:

### YOUR RESULT



#### Slow season (0.8×)

needed –  in-house =

From Step 1 & 2 From Step 3



#### Regular month

needed –  in-house =



#### Busy month (1.5×)

needed –  in-house =

! Run it again every quarter: the number moves with the calendar.

# Solutions to Fill Your Gap

Now that you know your gap hours, these are our matching recommendations:



**Hiring fits when** demand is high, steady, and mostly one kind of work: enough volume, every week, to keep a full-time designer busy.



**A specialist freelancer fits when** you need one specific thing from someone excellent at exactly that thing: a signature illustration style, a niche craft, a one-off piece outside your team's usual lane.



**Ad-hoc services fit when** only your busy-period gap is real: a launch, an event season, one big project. An occasional spike needs occasional help.



**A design subscription fits when** your regular-month gap is real: short even in an average month, across changing formats and channels. You get a designer who learns your brand and stays on it, with the hours sized to your gap: the ongoing work covered, without the hiring.

**Thanks for reading,** and I hope this interactive tool helps!



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# Leaning toward the subscription option? **Let's talk.**

We'll help you see if a design subscription is a real fit, within your number and your budget. If it is, the subscription gets you a design team running production for you, without the hiring.

**Book my 15-minute call**

**Book a Call**



P.S. The interactive version of this formula lives at [andelo.com.au/design-hours-guide](https://andelo.com.au/design-hours-guide): it does all the maths for you, live. Bookmark it for next quarter's re-run.

Sources and method: full-time hours use the Australian 38-hour standard week (Fair Work Act, National Employment Standards). Production benchmarks come from Andelo's estimate records across client briefs, published in full at [andelo.com.au/blog/how-long-design-takes](https://andelo.com.au/blog/how-long-design-takes). The 20% working margin and the 80% working-time rate are Andelo planning standards, from running this framework on our own team every quarter.

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